

legoESM: A Differentiable Earth System Model in JAX

Technical Documentation of Equations and Implementations

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Introduction

legoESM is a modular Earth System Model written entirely in JAX, supporting automatic differentiation through all components. The model couples atmospheric, oceanic, land, and sea-ice components on the sphere, with nine dynamical cores and over thirty physics parameterisations.

Design principles.

- Pure-JAX implementation: all components are compatible with `jit`, `grad`, and `vmap`.
- Modular physics: each parameterisation follows a factory pattern returning a callable `physics_fn(state, grid, coord) → Tendencities`.
- Multiple dynamical cores share the same physics interface, enabling interchangeable experiments.
- Neural-network components (SFNO) integrate seamlessly via the same JAX computational graph.

Grid Systems

Cubed-Sphere Grid

Six faces of a cube are mapped to the sphere via **gnomonic (central) projection**. Let $(\alpha_x, \alpha_y) \in [-\pi/4, \pi/4]^2$ be gnomonic coordinates on a face.

Face-to-Cartesian mapping

For face 0 (+x face):

$$(x, y, z) = (1, \tan \alpha_x, \tan \alpha_y), \quad (1)$$

with analogous expressions for the remaining five faces. Points are normalised to the unit sphere: $\hat{\mathbf{r}} = \mathbf{r}/|\mathbf{r}|$, and geographic coordinates follow as $\lambda = \text{atan2}(\hat{y}, \hat{x})$, $\phi = \arcsin(\hat{z})$.

Cell area

The area element on the gnomonic equidistant grid is

$$\Delta A = \frac{R^2 \Delta \alpha^2}{\cos^2 \alpha_x \cos^2 \alpha_y D^3}, \quad D = \sqrt{1 + \tan^2 \alpha_x + \tan^2 \alpha_y}, \quad \Delta \alpha = \frac{\pi}{2n}. \quad (2)$$

Grid spacing

Great-circle distances use the chord-to-arc formula:

$$d = R \cdot 2 \arcsin\left(\frac{|\mathbf{r}_1 - \mathbf{r}_2|}{2}\right). \quad (3)$$

Metric factors $\Delta x_{i,j}$ and $\Delta y_{i,j}$ are computed as two-cell spans for second-order centred differences.

Grid angle and wind rotation

The angle θ between the grid x -axis and geographic east is

$$\theta = \text{atan2}\left(\frac{\partial \phi}{\partial i}, \frac{\partial \lambda}{\partial i} \cos \phi\right). \quad (4)$$

Wind rotation between geographic (u_E, v_N) and grid-aligned (u_g, v_g) :

$$\begin{pmatrix} u_E \\ v_N \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} \cos \theta & -\sin \theta \\ \sin \theta & \cos \theta \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} u_g \\ v_g \end{pmatrix}. \quad (5)$$

Halo exchange

Scalar fields are exchanged directly across the six-face connectivity table. Vector fields are first rotated to geographic components, padded as scalars, then rotated back using the padded grid angle.

Gaussian Grid and Spectral Transforms

The spectral dynamical cores use a Gaussian grid with triangular truncation at total wavenumber $n_{\max}$.

Grid dimensions

$$n_{\text{lat}} = \lceil \frac{3}{2}(n_{\max} + 1) \rceil_{\text{even}}, \quad n_{\text{lon}} = 2 n_{\text{lat}}, \quad n_{\text{sh}} = \frac{(n_{\max} + 1)(n_{\max} + 2)}{2}. \quad (6)$$

Latitudes are Gaussian quadrature points $\mu_k = \sin \phi_k$ with weights w_k ; longitudes are equispaced.

Associated Legendre polynomials

Fully normalised (4π) polynomials $P_n^m(\mu)$ satisfy $\int |Y_n^m|^2 dA = 1$. They are computed via the recursion

$$P_m^m = -\sqrt{\frac{2m+1}{2m}} \sqrt{1-\mu^2} P_{m-1}^{m-1}, \quad (7)$$

$$P_n^m = \sqrt{\frac{4n^2-1}{n^2-m^2}} \left(\mu P_{n-1}^m - \sqrt{\frac{(n-1)^2-m^2}{4(n-1)^2-1}} P_{n-2}^m \right). \quad (8)$$

The derivative operator $H_n^m = -(1-\mu^2) dP_n^m/d\mu$ is used for meridional gradients.

Spherical harmonic transforms

Analysis (grid $\rightarrow$ spectral).

$$\hat{f}_{nm} = 2\pi \sum_k w_k P_n^m(\mu_k) \tilde{f}_m(\mu_k), \quad \tilde{f}_m = \frac{1}{n_{\text{lon}}} \text{FFT}[f]_m. \quad (9)$$

Synthesis (spectral $\rightarrow$ grid).

$$f(\phi, \lambda) = \text{iFFT} \left[\sum_{n=m}^{n_{\max}} \hat{f}_{nm} P_n^m(\mu) \right]. \quad (10)$$

Spectral operators

Laplacian eigenvalue: $\nabla^2 \hat{f}_{nm} = -n(n+1)/a^2 \cdot \hat{f}_{nm}$. Inverse Laplacian: $\nabla^{-2} \hat{f}_{nm} = -a^2/[n(n+1)]$ for $n > 0$. Hyperdiffusion: $-\nu[n(n+1)/a^2]^p \hat{f}_{nm}$.

Velocity from vorticity and divergence

Streamfunction $\psi = \nabla^{-2} \zeta$, velocity potential $\chi = \nabla^{-2} \delta$. Velocity reconstruction:

$$u \cos \phi = \frac{\partial \psi}{\partial \theta} + \frac{\partial \chi}{\partial \lambda}, \quad v \cos \phi = \frac{\partial \psi}{\partial \lambda} - \frac{\partial \chi}{\partial \theta}, \quad (11)$$

where θ is colatitude.

Sigma Vertical Coordinate

$$\sigma = p / p_s, \quad \sigma \in [\sigma_{\text{top}}, 1]. \quad (12)$$

Half-level interfaces $\sigma_{k+1/2}$ are uniformly spaced; full levels $\sigma_k = (\sigma_{k-1/2} + \sigma_{k+1/2})/2$. Layer thickness $\Delta\sigma_k = \sigma_{k+1/2} - \sigma_{k-1/2}$.

Simmons–Burridge geopotential

The geopotential at full level k is

$$\Phi_k = \Phi_s + R_d \sum_{k'=k+1}^{N-1} T_{k'} \ln \frac{\sigma_{k'+1/2}}{\sigma_{k'-1/2}} + \alpha_k R_d T_k, \quad (13)$$

where the Simmons–Burridge coefficient is

$$\alpha_k = 1 - \frac{\sigma_{k-1/2}}{\Delta\sigma_k} \ln \frac{\sigma_{k+1/2}}{\sigma_{k-1/2}}. \quad (14)$$

Sigma-dot

The vertical velocity in σ -space is obtained by integrating the continuity equation from the model top ($\dot{\sigma} = 0$):

$$\dot{\sigma}_{k+1/2} = \frac{\sigma_{k+1/2} - \sigma_{\text{top}}}{1 - \sigma_{\text{top}}} D_{\text{tot}} - \sum_{k'=0}^k \nabla \cdot \mathbf{v}_{k'} \Delta\sigma_{k'}, \quad D_{\text{tot}} = \sum_{k'=0}^{N-1} \nabla \cdot \mathbf{v}_{k'} \Delta\sigma_{k'}. \quad (15)$$

Pressure velocity

Since $p = \sigma p_s$, the material pressure tendency is

$$\omega \equiv \frac{dp}{dt} = \sigma \frac{dp_s}{dt} + p_s \dot{\sigma}, \quad (16)$$

where dp_s/dt is the *material* derivative of surface pressure (Eulerian tendency plus advection by the horizontal wind).

Height and z^* Coordinates

The terrain-following z^* coordinate:

$$z^* = H \frac{z - z_s}{H - z_s}, \quad J = \frac{\partial z}{\partial z^*} = \frac{H - z_s}{H}. \quad (17)$$

Physical height: $z(z^*, x, y) = z_s + z^* (H - z_s)/H$.

For the **ocean**, the z^* coordinate has a dynamic Jacobian:

$$J(\eta) = \frac{\eta + H}{H_{\text{max}}}, \quad (18)$$

where η is the free-surface elevation and H the resting depth.

Core Operators

All finite-difference operators use second-order centred differences on the A-grid (collocated) with halo padding on the cubed sphere. The discrete difference operators δ_i and δ_j are defined as centred differences of *cell-centre* values on the padded grid:

$$\delta_i[q]_{i,j} = q_{i+1,j} - q_{i-1,j}, \quad \delta_j[q]_{i,j} = q_{i,j+1} - q_{i,j-1}. \quad (19)$$

All metric-weighted fluxes ($u h_y, v h_x$) are evaluated at cell centres before differencing, consistent with the A-grid stencil.

Gradient

$$\left. \frac{\partial f}{\partial x} \right|_{i,j} = \frac{f_{i+1,j} - f_{i-1,j}}{2 \Delta x_{i,j}}, \quad \left. \frac{\partial f}{\partial y} \right|_{i,j} = \frac{f_{i,j+1} - f_{i,j-1}}{2 \Delta y_{i,j}}. \quad (20)$$

Divergence (flux form)

$$\nabla \cdot (u, v) = \frac{1}{2 A_{i,j}} \left[\delta_i(u h_y) + \delta_j(v h_x) \right], \quad (21)$$

where $h_x = \Delta x/2$, $h_y = \Delta y/2$ are half-edge lengths and A is the cell area.

Vorticity

$$\zeta = \frac{1}{2 A_{i,j}} \left[\delta_i(v h_y) - \delta_j(u h_x) \right]. \quad (22)$$

Laplacian and Hyperdiffusion

$$\nabla^2 f = \nabla \cdot (\nabla f), \quad \text{Hyperdiffusion:} \quad -\nu \nabla^4 f = -\nu \nabla^2 (\nabla^2 f). \quad (23)$$

Atmospheric Dynamics

Shallow Water Equations

In **vector-invariant form** on the cubed sphere:

$$\frac{\partial h}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot (h \mathbf{v}), \quad (24)$$

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial t} = (\zeta + f) v - \frac{\partial B}{\partial x} + D_u, \quad (25)$$

$$\frac{\partial v}{\partial t} = -(\zeta + f) u - \frac{\partial B}{\partial y} + D_v, \quad (26)$$

where the Bernoulli function is $B = \frac{1}{2}(u^2 + v^2) + g(h + h_s)$ and D_u, D_v represent hyperdiffusion.

Hydrostatic Primitive Equations (σ -coordinates)

Prognostic variables: u, v (winds), T (temperature), p_s (surface pressure).

$$\frac{\partial p_s}{\partial t} = - \int_0^1 \nabla \cdot (p_s \mathbf{v}) d\sigma, \quad (27)$$

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial t} = (\zeta + f) v - \frac{\partial B}{\partial x} - R_d T \frac{\partial \ln p_s}{\partial x} + D_u, \quad (28)$$

$$\frac{\partial v}{\partial t} = -(\zeta + f) u - \frac{\partial B}{\partial y} - R_d T \frac{\partial \ln p_s}{\partial y} + D_v, \quad (29)$$

$$\frac{\partial T}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot (T \mathbf{v}) + T \nabla \cdot \mathbf{v} - \dot{\sigma} \frac{\partial T}{\partial \sigma} + \kappa T \frac{\omega}{p} + Q, \quad (30)$$

where $B = K + \Phi$, $K = \frac{1}{2}(u^2 + v^2)$, and $\kappa = R_d/c_p$.

Spectral Primitive Equations (Vorticity–Divergence)

On the Gaussian grid, the momentum equations are recast in the vorticity–divergence form (Bourke, 1972):

$$\frac{\partial \hat{\zeta}}{\partial t} = \nabla \times [\widehat{[(\zeta + f)\mathbf{v}]}] + \widehat{\text{vert. adv.}} - \nu \nabla^{2p} \hat{\zeta}, \quad (31)$$

$$\frac{\partial \hat{\delta}}{\partial t} = \nabla \cdot [\widehat{[(\zeta + f)\mathbf{v}]}] - \nabla^2 (K + \Phi + R_d T \ln p_s) + \widehat{\text{vert. adv.}} - \nu \nabla^{2p} \hat{\delta}, \quad (32)$$

$$\frac{\partial \hat{T}}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot (\widehat{T\mathbf{v}}) + T \nabla \cdot \mathbf{v} - \dot{\sigma} \widehat{\partial T / \partial \sigma} + \kappa T \widehat{\omega/p}, \quad (33)$$

$$\frac{\partial \widehat{\ln p_s}}{\partial t} = - \int_0^1 \hat{\delta} d\sigma. \quad (34)$$

The spectral curl and divergence of flux vectors $(U, V) = (F_u \cos \phi, F_v \cos \phi)$ are

$$\widehat{\text{curl}} = \frac{im}{a} \mathcal{S}[V/\cos^2 \phi] + \frac{1}{a} \mathcal{S}_\mu[U], \quad \widehat{\text{div}} = \frac{im}{a} \mathcal{S}[U/\cos^2 \phi] - \frac{1}{a} \mathcal{S}_\mu[V], \quad (35)$$

where $\mathcal{S}$ and $\mathcal{S}_\mu$ denote the SH analysis with standard and $dP_n^m/d\mu$ Legendre matrices.

Non-Hydrostatic Compressible Euler Equations

In the z^* terrain-following coordinate, the prognostic variables are u, v, w, θ', ρ' (perturbations from a reference state ρ_0, θ_0, π_0).

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial t} = (\zeta + f) v - \frac{\partial K}{\partial x} - c_p \theta \frac{\partial \pi'}{\partial x} + D_u - r u, \quad (36)$$

$$\frac{\partial v}{\partial t} = -(\zeta + f) u - \frac{\partial K}{\partial y} - c_p \theta \frac{\partial \pi'}{\partial y} + D_v - r v, \quad (37)$$

$$\frac{\partial w}{\partial t} = -\frac{c_p \theta}{J} \frac{\partial \pi'}{\partial z^*} - g \frac{\theta'}{\theta_0} - r w, \quad (38)$$

$$\frac{\partial \theta'}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot (\theta \mathbf{v}_h) - \frac{w}{J} \frac{\partial \theta}{\partial z^*} + D_\theta, \quad (39)$$

$$\frac{\partial \rho'}{\partial t} = -\frac{1}{J} \left[\nabla_h \cdot (J \rho \mathbf{v}_h) + \frac{\partial(\rho w)}{\partial z^*} \right], \quad (40)$$

where $r(z)$ is the sponge-layer Rayleigh damping coefficient and the Exner function perturbation is

$$\pi' = \pi_0 \left[\left(1 + \frac{\rho'}{\rho_0} \right) \left(1 + \frac{\theta'}{\theta_0} \right) \right]^{R_d/c_v} - \pi_0. \quad (41)$$

Split-explicit time integration

The equations are integrated with an outer SSP-RK3 scheme for the slow tendencies (advection, Coriolis, horizontal pressure gradient, diffusion) and inner forward–backward acoustic substeps for the fast variables (w, θ', ρ') .

Forward step (w).

$$w^{n+1} = w^n + \Delta t_s \left[-\frac{c_p \theta}{J} \frac{\partial \pi'}{\partial z^*} - g \frac{\theta'}{\theta_0} \right]. \quad (42)$$

Backward step (ρ', θ').

$$\rho'^{n+1} = \rho'^n - \Delta t_s \frac{\partial(\rho w^{n+1})}{\partial z^*}, \quad \theta'^{n+1} = \theta'^n - \Delta t_s \frac{w^{n+1}}{J} \frac{\partial \theta}{\partial z^*}. \quad (43)$$

An optional **semi-implicit acoustic** solve replaces the forward Euler for w with a tridiagonal system to remove the vertical acoustic CFL constraint.

Sponge layer

$$r(z) = r_{\max} \sin^2 \left(\frac{\pi}{2} \frac{\max(0, z - z_{\text{bot}})}{z_{\text{top}} - z_{\text{bot}}} \right). \quad (44)$$

Atmospheric Physics

Gray Radiation (Frierson 2006)

Longwave optical depth

$$\tau(\sigma, \phi) = [f_l \sigma + (1 - f_l) \sigma^4] [\tau_e + (\tau_p - \tau_e) \sin^2 \phi] + \tau_{\text{moist}} q_v, \quad (45)$$

with $\tau_e = 7.2$, $\tau_p = 1.8$, $f_l = 0.2$, $\tau_{\text{moist}} = 1150$.

Two-stream LW fluxes

Layer transmittance and emissivity:

$$\mathcal{T}_k = e^{-D \Delta \tau_k}, \quad \varepsilon_k = 1 - \mathcal{T}_k, \quad D = 1.66. \quad (46)$$

Upward sweep from surface ($F_{\text{sfc}}^\uparrow = \varepsilon_s \sigma_{\text{SB}} T_s^4$):

$$F_k^\uparrow = \mathcal{T}_k F_{k+1}^\uparrow + \varepsilon_k \sigma_{\text{SB}} T_k^4. \quad (47)$$

Downward sweep from TOA ($F_0^\downarrow = 0$):

$$F_k^\downarrow = \mathcal{T}_k F_{k-1}^\downarrow + \varepsilon_k \sigma_{\text{SB}} T_k^4. \quad (48)$$

Shortwave (Beer–Lambert)

$$F_{\text{SW}}^\downarrow(k) = \frac{S_0}{4} e^{-D \tau_{\text{SW},0} \sigma_k}, \quad F_{\text{SW}}^\uparrow(k) = \alpha_s F_{\text{SW}}^\downarrow(\text{sfc}) e^{-D \tau_{\text{SW},0} (1 - \sigma_k)}, \quad (49)$$

with $\tau_{\text{SW},0} = 0.22$, $S_0 = 1360 \text{ W m}^{-2}$, $\alpha_s = 0.31$.

Heating rate

Defining $F_{\text{net}}^\uparrow = F^\uparrow - F^\downarrow$ (upward positive) at each interface, the heating rate for layer k is

$$\left. \frac{dT}{dt} \right|_{\text{rad},k} = \frac{g}{c_p} \frac{F_{\text{net},k+1/2}^\uparrow - F_{\text{net},k-1/2}^\uparrow}{p_{k+1/2} - p_{k-1/2}}, \quad (50)$$

where $k + \frac{1}{2}$ is the bottom interface and $k - \frac{1}{2}$ the top (pressure increasing downward). Positive divergence of upward flux warms the layer.

RRTMGP Correlated- k Radiation

The RRTMGP wrapper calls JAX-RRTMGP with correlated- k gaseous optics (128 LW and 112 SW g -points), a two-stream RTE solver, and optional cloud optics. Default trace-gas concentrations: CO₂=415 ppmv, CH₄=1900 ppbv, N₂O=332 ppbv.

SBM Convection (Frierson 2007)

Moist adiabatic lapse rate

$$\Gamma_m = \frac{R_d T}{c_p p} \frac{1 + L_v q_s / (R_d T)}{1 + L_v^2 q_s / (c_p R_v T^2)}, \quad (51)$$

integrated upward via a trapezoidal predictor-corrector.

Saturation mixing ratio (Tetens)

$$e_s = 611.2 \exp\left(\frac{17.67 T_c}{T_c + 243.5}\right), \quad q_s = \frac{\varepsilon e_s}{p - e_s}, \quad \varepsilon = R_d / R_v \approx 0.622. \quad (52)$$

CAPE and trigger

$$\text{CAPE} = R_d \sum_k \max(0, T_{\text{parcel},k} - T_{\text{env},k}) \frac{\Delta p_k}{p_k}. \quad (53)$$

A smooth sigmoid trigger activates convection:

$$\mathcal{F} = \sigma(\kappa_s (\text{CAPE} - \text{CAPE}_c)), \quad \kappa_s = 0.01 \text{ (J/kg)}^{-1}. \quad (54)$$

Enthalpy-conserving relaxation

The reference profile T_{ref} is obtained by adjusting the moist adiabat so that column-integrated moist enthalpy is conserved:

$$\sum_k [c_p (T_{\text{ref},k} - T_k) + L_v (q_{\text{ref},k} - q_{v,k})] \Delta p_k = 0. \quad (55)$$

Newton iteration (2 steps) solves for the temperature offset. Tendencies:

$$\frac{dT}{dt} = \mathcal{F} \frac{T_{\text{ref}} - T}{\tau_c}, \quad \frac{dq_v}{dt} = \mathcal{F} \frac{q_{\text{ref}} - q_v}{\tau_c}, \quad \tau_c = 7200 \text{ s}. \quad (56)$$

Precipitation

$$P = -\frac{1}{g} \sum_k \frac{dq_v}{dt} \Delta p_k. \quad (57)$$

Held–Suarez Forcing

Equilibrium temperature

$$T_{\text{eq}} = \max\left(200, \left[315 - \Delta T_y \sin^2 \phi - \Delta \theta_z \ln(p/p_0) \cos^2 \phi\right] (p/p_0)^\kappa\right), \quad (58)$$

with $\Delta T_y = 60$ K, $\Delta \theta_z = 10$ K.

Newtonian relaxation

$$\frac{dT}{dt} = -k_T(\sigma, \phi) (T - T_{\text{eq}}), \quad k_T = k_a + (k_s - k_a) \max\left(0, \frac{\sigma - \sigma_b}{1 - \sigma_b}\right) \cos^4 \phi, \quad (59)$$

with $k_a = 1/(40 \text{ day})$, $k_s = 1/(4 \text{ day})$, $\sigma_b = 0.7$.

Rayleigh friction

$$\frac{d\mathbf{v}}{dt} = -k_v(\sigma) \mathbf{v}, \quad k_v = k_f \max\left(0, \frac{\sigma - \sigma_b}{1 - \sigma_b}\right), \quad k_f = 1/(1 \text{ day}). \quad (60)$$

Louis (1979) Turbulence

Mixing length

$$l = \frac{\kappa_{\text{vK}} z}{1 + \kappa_{\text{vK}} z/l_{\text{max}}}, \quad \kappa_{\text{vK}} = 0.4, \quad l_{\text{max}} = 100 \text{ m}. \quad (61)$$

Richardson number

$$\text{Ri} = \frac{N^2}{S^2}, \quad N^2 = \frac{g}{\theta_v} \frac{\partial \theta_v}{\partial z}, \quad S^2 = \left(\frac{\partial u}{\partial z}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{\partial v}{\partial z}\right)^2. \quad (62)$$

Stability functions

$$f_m(\text{Ri}) = \begin{cases} 1 - \frac{2b \text{ Ri}}{1 + 3bc l^2 |\text{Ri}|^{1/2} / \Delta z^2} & \text{Ri} < 0, \\ \frac{1}{1 + 2b \text{ Ri} / \sqrt{1 + d \text{ Ri}}} & \text{Ri} \geq 0, \end{cases} \quad (63)$$

with $b = c = d = 5$. Eddy diffusivities: $K_m = l^2 S f_m$, $K_h = K_m$.

Vertical Diffusion (Implicit Thomas Algorithm)

The backward-Euler system $-a_k \varphi_{k-1} + b_k \varphi_k - c_k \varphi_{k+1} = d_k$ is solved with the Thomas algorithm.

Tridiagonal coefficients.

$$a_k = \frac{\Delta t K_{k-1/2}}{\rho_k \Delta z_k \Delta z_{k-1/2}}, \quad c_k = \frac{\Delta t K_{k+1/2}}{\rho_k \Delta z_k \Delta z_{k+1/2}}, \quad b_k = 1 + a_k + c_k. \quad (64)$$

Forward sweep.

$$w_k = \frac{a_k}{b'_{k-1}}, \quad b'_k = b_k - w_k c_{k-1}, \quad d'_k = d_k + w_k d'_{k-1}. \quad (65)$$

Back substitution.

$$\varphi_k = \frac{d'_k + c_k \varphi_{k+1}}{b'_k}. \quad (66)$$

Surface Fluxes (Bulk Aerodynamic)

$$\tau_x = -\rho C_D |\mathbf{V}| u, \quad \tau_y = -\rho C_D |\mathbf{V}| v, \quad (67)$$

$$\text{SH} = \rho c_p C_H |\mathbf{V}| (T_s - T_a), \quad (68)$$

$$\text{LH} = \rho L_v C_H |\mathbf{V}| (q_s - q_a), \quad (69)$$

with $C_D = C_H = 1.5 \times 10^{-3}$ and $|\mathbf{V}| = \sqrt{u^2 + v^2 + 10^{-4}}$.

Ocean Dynamics

Boussinesq Hydrostatic Primitive Equations

In vector-invariant form on the cubed sphere:

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial t} = (\zeta + f) v - \frac{\partial K}{\partial x} - \frac{1}{\rho_0} \frac{\partial p'}{\partial x} + A_h \nabla^2 u + \frac{\partial}{\partial z} \left(A_v \frac{\partial u}{\partial z} \right) - w \frac{\partial u}{\partial z}, \quad (70)$$

$$\frac{\partial v}{\partial t} = -(\zeta + f) u - \frac{\partial K}{\partial y} - \frac{1}{\rho_0} \frac{\partial p'}{\partial y} + A_h \nabla^2 v + \frac{\partial}{\partial z} \left(A_v \frac{\partial v}{\partial z} \right) - w \frac{\partial v}{\partial z}. \quad (71)$$

The Coriolis force is split: depth-mean $f\mathbf{v}$ in the barotropic substeps, baroclinic shear $f\mathbf{v}'$ in the slow tendencies.

Tracer equations (skew-symmetric)

$$\frac{\partial \phi}{\partial t} = \frac{1}{2} \left[-\mathbf{v} \cdot \nabla \phi - \nabla \cdot (\phi \mathbf{v}) \right] - w \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial z} + K_h \nabla^2 \phi + \frac{\partial}{\partial z} \left(K_v \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial z} \right). \quad (72)$$

Free-surface equation

$$\frac{\partial \eta}{\partial t} = - \sum_k \nabla \cdot (h_k \mathbf{v}_k). \quad (73)$$

Barotropic Solver (Forward–Backward, Semi-Implicit Coriolis)

The barotropic system is solved with split-explicit forward–backward substeps:

$$\frac{\partial \eta}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot (H \bar{\mathbf{V}}), \quad \frac{\partial \bar{\mathbf{V}}}{\partial t} = f \hat{\mathbf{k}} \times \bar{\mathbf{V}} - g \nabla \eta + \mathbf{F}_{\text{slow}}. \quad (74)$$

Semi-implicit Coriolis. With $\alpha = \frac{1}{2} f \Delta t_s$:

$$\bar{U}^{n+1} = \frac{R_u + \alpha R_v}{1 + \alpha^2}, \quad \bar{V}^{n+1} = \frac{R_v - \alpha R_u}{1 + \alpha^2}, \quad (75)$$

where $R_u = \bar{U}^n + \alpha \bar{V}^n - \Delta t_s g \partial \eta / \partial x$ and $R_v = \bar{V}^n - \alpha \bar{U}^n - \Delta t_s g \partial \eta / \partial y$.

Equation of State (Wright 1997)

$$\rho = \frac{p + p_0(T, S)}{\lambda(T, S) + \alpha_0(T, S)(p + p_0)}, \quad (76)$$

where

$$\alpha_0 = a_0 + a_1 T + a_2 S, \quad (77)$$

$$p_0 = (b_0 + b_4 S) + T(b_1 + T(b_2 + b_3 T) + b_5 S), \quad (78)$$

$$\lambda = (c_0 + c_4 S) + T(c_1 + T(c_2 + c_3 T) + c_5 S). \quad (79)$$

Coefficients follow the MOM6 implementation. The density perturbation is $\rho' = \rho(T, S, p) - \rho_0$.

Hydrostatic Pressure and Vertical Velocity

Baroclinic pressure by downward integration:

$$p'_k = \rho_0 g \eta + \sum_{k'=0}^{k-1} \rho'_{k'} g \Delta z_{k'} + \frac{1}{2} \rho'_k g \Delta z_k. \quad (80)$$

Vertical velocity diagnosed bottom-up from $w(\text{floor}) = 0$:

$$w_{k-1/2} = - \sum_{k'=k}^{N-1} \nabla \cdot (h_{k'} \mathbf{v}_{k'}). \quad (81)$$

Time Integration

SSP-RK3 (Shu–Osher 1988)

The three-stage strong-stability-preserving Runge–Kutta method:

$$\mathbf{u}^{(1)} = \mathbf{u}^n + \Delta t F(\mathbf{u}^n), \quad (82)$$

$$\mathbf{u}^{(2)} = \frac{3}{4} \mathbf{u}^n + \frac{1}{4} \mathbf{u}^{(1)} + \frac{1}{4} \Delta t F(\mathbf{u}^{(1)}), \quad (83)$$

$$\mathbf{u}^{n+1} = \frac{1}{3} \mathbf{u}^n + \frac{2}{3} \mathbf{u}^{(2)} + \frac{2}{3} \Delta t F(\mathbf{u}^{(2)}). \quad (84)$$

SSP-RK(4,3) and SSP-RK(5,4) variants are also available.

Split-Explicit Methods

Each outer RK stage computes slow tendencies once, updates u, v and tracers, then runs N_s forward–backward acoustic substeps on the fast variables (w, θ', ρ') with substep size $\Delta t_s = \Delta t / N_s$.

Land, Ice, and Coupler

Slab Land Model

Energy balance

$$C_s d_s \frac{dT_s}{dt} = (1 - \alpha_l) SW^\downarrow + \varepsilon_l (LW^\downarrow - \sigma_{\text{SB}} T_s^4) - SH - LH. \quad (85)$$

Bucket hydrology

$$\frac{dW}{dt} = P - E, \quad W \in [0, W_{\max}]. \quad (86)$$

Moisture availability $\beta = \beta_{\min} + (1 - \beta_{\min}) W/W_{\max}$ modulates evaporation via $q_{\text{sfc}} = \beta q_s(T_s)$.

Sea-Ice Model

Surface temperature

$$\rho_i c_i \frac{h_{\text{eff}}}{2} \frac{dT_i}{dt} = Q_{\text{sfc}} - \frac{k_i(T_f - T_i)}{h_{\text{eff}}}, \quad h_{\text{eff}} = \max(h_i, h_{\min}). \quad (87)$$

Growth and melt

$$\frac{dh_i}{dt} = \frac{F_{\text{cond}} - F_{\text{ocean}}}{\rho_i L_f}. \quad (88)$$

Concentration

$$\frac{dc}{dt} = \begin{cases} (dh/dt)(1 - c)/h_{\text{new}} & \text{growing,} \\ (dh/dt) c/h_{\text{eff}} & \text{melting.} \end{cases} \quad (89)$$

Tile Coupler

Surface fluxes are area-weighted blends over ocean, land, sea-ice, and lake tiles:

$$X_{\text{blend}} = f_{\text{ocn}} X_{\text{ocn}} + f_{\text{land}} X_{\text{land}} + f_{\text{ice}} X_{\text{ice}} + f_{\text{lake}} X_{\text{lake}}. \quad (90)$$

Fluxes are time-averaged over each coupling window before being passed to the atmosphere.

Machine Learning: Spherical Fourier Neural Operator

The SFNO (ACE/FourCastNet v2 style) operates on the Gaussian grid.

Architecture

1. **Encoder:** Pointwise linear $n_{\text{in}} \rightarrow n_{\text{emb}}$.
2. **N processor blocks**, each containing:
 - Layer normalisation,
 - SH analysis $\rightarrow$ learned spectral convolution $\rightarrow$ SH synthesis,
 - GELU activation,
 - Pointwise MLP (two layers with expansion factor),
 - Skip connection.
3. **Decoder:** Pointwise linear $n_{\text{emb}} \rightarrow n_{\text{out}}$.
4. **Big-skip residual:** output = input + decoder($\dots$).

Spectral convolution

In the SH coefficient space:

$$\hat{f}_{nm}^{\text{out}} = W_{nm} \hat{f}_{nm}^{\text{in}}, \quad (91)$$

where $W_{nm} \in \mathbb{R}^{n_{\text{emb}} \times n_{\text{emb}}}$ is a learnable weight matrix per wavenumber pair.

Conservation Corrections

Atmosphere

Dry-air mass is corrected by a uniform adjustment to p_s that restores the area-weighted global integral:

$$\Delta\bar{p} = \frac{\sum_i A_i p_{s,i}^{\text{new}} - \sum_i A_i p_{s,i}^{\text{old}}}{\sum_i A_i}, \quad p_{s,i}^{\text{corr}} = p_{s,i}^{\text{new}} - \Delta\bar{p}, \quad (92)$$

so that $\sum_i A_i p_{s,i}^{\text{corr}} = \sum_i A_i p_{s,i}^{\text{old}}$ (global dry mass conserved exactly). Column moisture is rescaled: $q^{\text{corr}} = q^{\text{new}} \cdot Q_{\text{old}}/Q_{\text{new}}$.

Ocean

Volume conservation: $\eta^{\text{corr}} = \eta^{\text{new}} + (\sum \eta_{\text{old}} A - \sum \eta_{\text{new}} A) / \sum A$.

Heat and salt conservation: uniform additive correction per unit volume.

Physical Constants

Symbol	Name	Value	Unit
g	Gravitational acceleration	9.80616	m s^{-2}
R_d	Dry-air gas constant	287.04	$\text{J kg}^{-1} \text{K}^{-1}$
c_p	Dry-air heat capacity	1005.0	$\text{J kg}^{-1} \text{K}^{-1}$
R_v	Water-vapour gas constant	461.5	$\text{J kg}^{-1} \text{K}^{-1}$
L_v	Latent heat of vapourisation	2.501×10^6	J kg^{-1}
κ	R_d/c_p	0.285	—
p_0	Reference pressure	10^5	Pa
σ_{SB}	Stefan–Boltzmann constant	5.67×10^{-8}	$\text{W m}^{-2} \text{K}^{-4}$
κ_{vK}	von Kármán constant	0.4	—
Ω	Earth rotation rate	7.292×10^{-5}	rad s^{-1}
$R_{\oplus}$	Earth radius	6.371×10^6	m
ρ_0	Ocean reference density	1025	kg m^{-3}

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